

Chapter 175-4

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Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi went to the hospital to bring soup to Zhao Xuning. Zhao Xuning woke up briefly but fell asleep again shortly after.

The Zhao family was watching from outside.

Xu Qingzhu also went to see Shen Hui.

Shen Fenghe had gone to the company, leaving only Shen Siyan in the hospital room to keep Shen Hui company.

Xu Qingzhu chatted with Shen Hui for a while, but Shen Hui looked listless and preoccupied.

Later, Shen Siyan came in to bring fruit for them. Shen Hui asked him: "Did you find anything?"

Shen Siyan hesitated, wanting to speak but stopping himself. Finally, he made an excuse: "No."

Shen Hui frowned slightly. "What about Big Sister? She didn't find anything either?"

"No." Shen Siyan wasn't good at lying. Whenever he lied, his eyes would dart around, and his voice sounded somewhat hollow. "Anyway, you've already decided to get back together with Zhao Xuning, so just drop the investigation."

"I still need to know what happened," Shen Hui said.

She needed to know what it was that made Zhao Xuning come to her side so resolutely, so recklessly.

"Then just wait for her to wake up and tell you herself." Shen Siyan tugged at his ear and hurried away.

Xu Qingzhu sat there watching Shen Siyan and noticed that his gesture of tugging his ear just now was very similar to Liang Shi's.

When nervous, they both liked to tug at their ears.

Two fingers lightly rubbing, then hastily pulling away, looking a bit embarrassed.

Xu Qingzhu stared at Shen Siyan's retreating figure for a while, only snapping back to attention when Shen Hui called her.

Shen Hui asked quietly: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu shook her head.

She could always vaguely see Liang Shi's shadow in Shen Hui and her family.

It was strange.

But if she added in their previous speculations, it wasn't strange at all.

However, Shen Hui was still hospitalized now, Shen Fenghe was swamped at the company, and the Shen parents probably didn't know about any of this yet. Xu Qingzhu decided to wait until she discussed it with Liang Shi before making any decisions.

Soon, she said goodbye and returned to the company.

In the evening, Liang Shi received a call from Chen Mian.

At that time, Liang Shi had just finished filming. After a highly emotional scene, her thoughts were still somewhat scattered, and she hadn't fully gotten out of character yet.

When she answered Chen Mian's call, her voice still had a tearful quality. Chen Mian paused briefly: "What's going on?"

"Ah... nothing." Liang Shi's tone was somewhat slow. "What did you need me for?"

There was the sound of pages turning on Chen Mian's end, then it went quiet: "Do you know Qiu Zimin?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I do." Liang Shi asked: "What about it?"

Chen Mian said: "She's offering fifty million to buy a piece in my collection."

"Uh." Liang Shi was slow to react, not knowing what this had to do with her.

Chen Mian continued: "This painting was done by a woman named Shen Chi. It depicts three women boating on a lake—Shen Chi, Zhu Mingqi, and Qiu Zimin. Their names are written in small text on the painting."

Liang Shi frowned slightly. She finally emerged somewhat from her earlier intense emotions, and her mind started working: "And then? Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin know each other?"

"They should." Chen Mian said: "If I remember correctly, Zhu Mingqi also once wanted to buy my paintings, saying my work was about fifty percent similar to that of an old acquaintance."

Liang Shi: "....."

"So that would be Shen Chi?" Liang Shi asked.

Chen Mian responded with a "mm." "I was trained in Shen Chi's lineage."

"So what does all this... have to do with me?" Liang Shi asked again.

She still couldn't figure it out.

"Or would you like to see this painting?" Chen Mian didn't say directly but went in a roundabout way.

Liang Shi didn't understand her intention but agreed anyway. "Then send it over."

Soon, Chen Mian hung up and sent her a photo.

Liang Shi looked at it and thought it was well painted. Also, the Qiu Zimin in the painting was much prettier than she was now. Zhu Mingqi looked familiar—probably because she had seen her at the art museum before.

She specifically zoomed in to look, then relayed her observations to Chen Mian.

After listening, Chen Mian went silent for a while.

Liang Shi: [What's wrong? Am I mistaken?]

Chen Mian: [Forget it, I won't make it difficult for you.]

Liang Shi: [.....]

After a while, Chen Mian sent her a voice message: "Because you probably look at things on the surface, but we painters look at bone structure. Haven't you noticed that Zhu Mingqi's bone structure is about seventy percent similar to yours? When I first saw it, I thought it was you."

Liang Shi: "?"

Chen Mian sent another message: "But that's just my guess, can't take it as fact. However, after I put out news about this painting, both Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin came to me wanting to buy it. Zhu Mingqi offered ten million, and Qiu Zimin offered fifty million."

Liang Shi: "...You're really rich."

Chen Mian: "?"

Liang Shi stared at the painting again and again but still didn't think the resemblance was that strong.

Maybe it was because she was too used to looking at herself.

However...

Liang Shi asked Chen Mian: "So what's the relationship between Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin?"

Chen Mian answered very straightforwardly: "Love rivals."

"Shen Chi had countless romantic rumors when she was young." Chen Mian said: "But she had two childhood sweethearts—one was her white moonlight, one was her cinnabar mole."¹

Liang Shi: "?"

You artists really have quite the romantic histories.

1. "White moonlight" (白月光) and "cinnabar mole" (朱砂痣) are Chinese literary terms for different types of unforgettable loves. "White moonlight" refers to a pure, idealized first love that one can never forget—someone unattainable and perfect in memory. "Cinnabar mole" refers to a love that leaves an indelible mark on one's heart, like a red mole that can never be erased. The terms come from a famous essay by Zhang Ailing (Eileen Chang), where she wrote that every man has two such women in his life. In modern usage, they represent two types of unforgettable past loves. ⇐